The committee met again on 28 April. It now considered the retired chairman of State Bank of India O.P. Bhatt, Anshu Jain of Deutsche Bank, Ravi Uppal of Larsen & Toubro and Vikram Pandit of Citibank. This meeting was important not only because the names of these industry heavyweights came up for consideration, but for the surprise emergence of a member of the selection committee—Cyrus Mistry—as a candidate.

The decision to include Mistry was mostly circumstantial. The committee was no closer to finding a candidate than when it had begun the search. Faced with this scenario, Mistry, who had authored a four-page note titled, 'Key Success Factors in Managing the Tata Group Under a Structure that Has the Chairman of Operating Companies as Different Individuals' on 11 October 2010, suddenly emerged as a candidate who could be considered for the post. This paper comprised his thoughts on the qualities that a chairman of Tata Sons should possess. It immediately caught the attention of the selection committee that had also observed that Mistry was actively participating in the interactions with the candidates. It left some of the members wondering why he should not be considered for the post.

As Krishna Kumar, the de facto chairman of the committee, recalled, Mistry had elaborated on what a chairman of Tata Sons should do and 'debated with the committee', positioning himself as a suitable candidate. In addition, the committee was 'running against a deadline' and 'RNT was adamant' on stepping down as announced. This put enormous pressure on it to identify a candidate at the earliest.

'We were not getting the correct candidate' and this led the committee to ask Mistry if he would like to be considered as a candidate, says Soonawala. 'If you all insist that I could be considered, then I will be happy,' Soonawala remembers Mistry responding. Soonawala says that he 'personally gave a lot of weightage' to the note. He thought, 'if he can do all this, he could be the right man'.

Once his name came up, Mistry left the room. After the committee had met other candidates, he was invited back to the meeting, now as a potential candidate. He was asked several questions by the committee members, ranging from his capacity to handle the 'government and its demands' to the issue of his foreign citizenship (Mistry was an Irish citizen).

The minutes drawn up by the committee, however, do not reveal the reason why it chose to meet Mistry a second time. The only plausible reason may have been its eagerness to find a successor before Ratan